

LIN7209 – Syntax

Agreement

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14/10/2025

Queen Mary University of London

Plan for today

- Agreement basics building on Phase Theory.
- Long Distance agreement in Tsez (Polinsky & Potsdam, 2001).

Agreement basics

Subject-verb agreement

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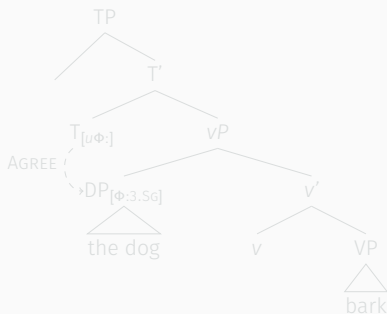
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 - May target **non-subjects** (e.g. objects), and even sometimes “**track**” **specific features** instead of specific syntactic positions.
- This all suggests Agreement is a **very general mechanism** in Syntax.

Agree as a Probe-Goal relationship

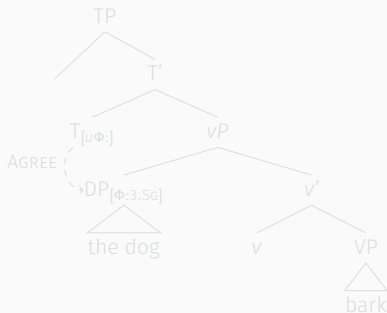
- Successful Agreement is a condition for **grammaticality**, and a potential **trigger for movement and Case assignment**.
- AGREE involves two kinds of elements: a **Probe** looking for specific features, and one or more **Goals** bearing these features.¹
- For instance, in English T is a Probe looking for Φ -features, and DPs like *the dog* bear Φ -features.



¹Here "Goal" has nothing to do with the same-name Θ -role!

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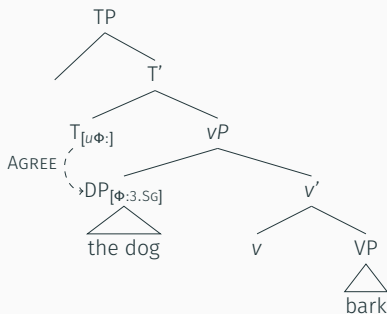
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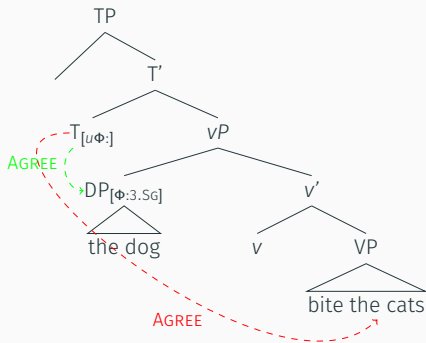
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- Probes normally look for Goals within their C-Command domain (i.e. **downward**).²
- They'll AGREE with the **highest** Goal (w.r.t. C-Command) bearing the right features.³

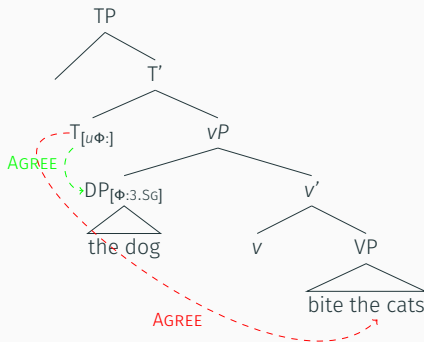


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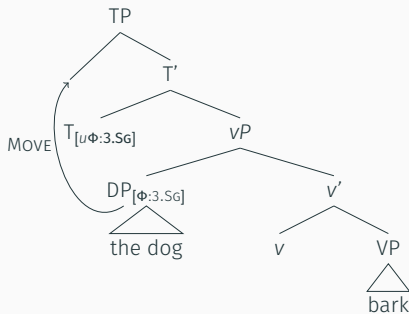


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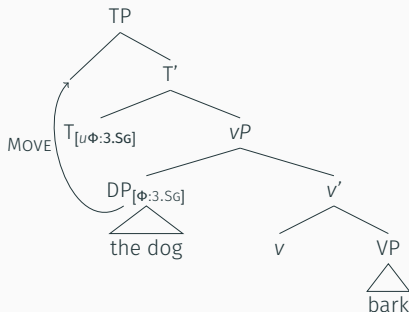
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- Once a Probe has found a Goal, it **copies its features**.
- The Probe may also **move the Goal to its Specifier**.
 - English T for instance, attracts its Goal (the subject) to Spec-TP. T is said to have an “EPP”-feature (for Extended Projection Principle), forcing Spec-TP to be filled, and so forcing movement.
 - T also assigns Case to the subject (in English, NOMINATIVE).



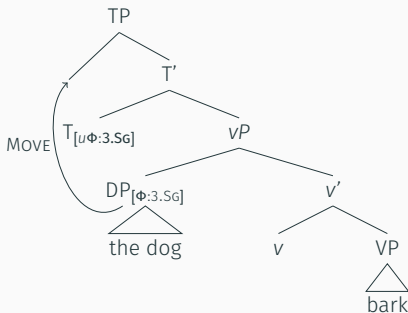
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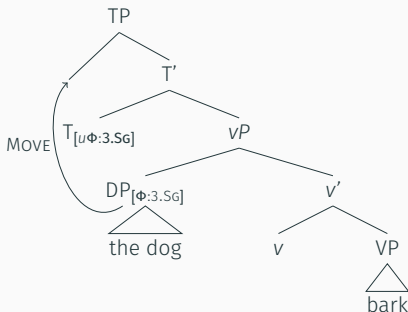
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Types of movement

- Two general kinds of movements can be identified cross-linguistically. Both can be seen as AGREE-driven. But they exhibit two relatively stable, and crucially distinct, clusters of properties.
- **A-movement** (e.g.: subject movement; raising; unaccusatives; passives). Local, creates new antecedents for binding, island-insensitive.
- **$\bar{A}$ -movement** (e.g.: *wh*-movement, topicalization). Unbounded,⁴ does not create new antecedents for binding, island-sensitive.
- Recall movement is just INTERNAL MERGE, which creates two copies of the moved element.
 - If the **higher** copy gets pronounced, we get **overt** movement.
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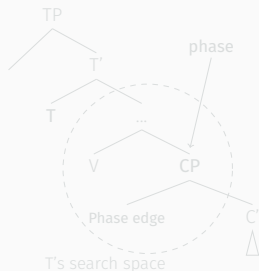
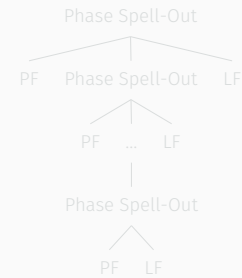
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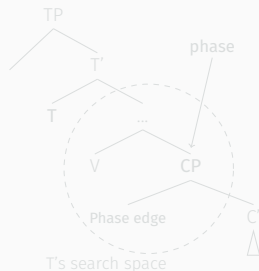
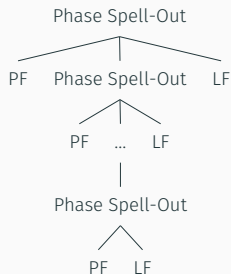


- Agreement is thought to be relatively local: the Probe cannot look “too far” down.⁵ Here’s why.
- CPs (and sometimes vPs) constitute “**phases**” sending everything they dominate but their Spec to LF and PF (“**Spell-Out**”).
- Spell-Out makes the inside of phasal projections **almost entirely opaque to upper Probes**. Only their Spec (Spec-CP, Spec-vP), called “**phase edge**” remains accessible. This is the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC).⁶

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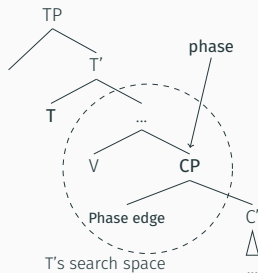
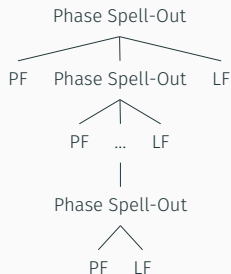


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Long Distance Agreement in Tsez

Ergative-Absolutive case system

- In English, subject and objects receive different **case markings**.
The subject will be NOMINATIVE, and the object ACCUSATIVE.

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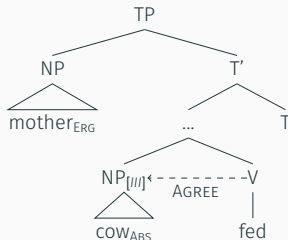
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- **The subject of an intransitive and the object of a transitive are marked with the ABSOLUTIVE case, and the subject of transitives bear ERGATIVE.**
- Tsez, Basque, Georgian, Mayan, Tibetan, Sumerian, and many Indo-Aryan languages are ERGATIVE-ABSOLUTIVE.

Tsez arguments

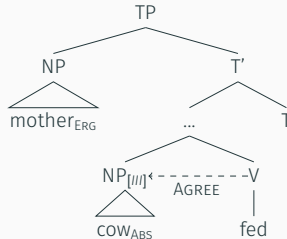
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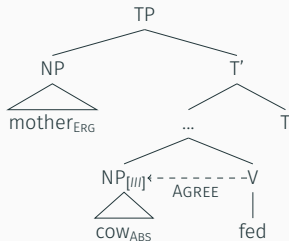
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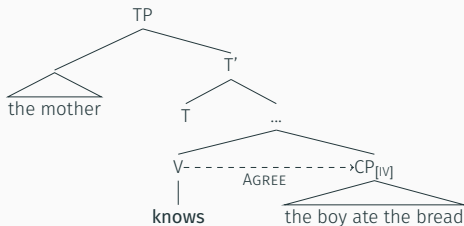
- To make things easier to process, I'll use head-initial trees from now on, even if Tsez has head-final Vs and Ts, as shown in the above tree.

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Starting with relatively standard Agreement...

- (3) enir [užā magalu bāc'ruḷi] r-iyxo
mother [boy bread.III.ABS ate].IV IV-know
'The mother knows the boy ate the bread.'

- The matrix verb agrees with its clausal absolutive complement.



- This is analog to the tree on the previous slide, the only difference is that now the object is a full CP.
- This kind of Agreement is in line with the PIC, because it does not dig beyond CP.

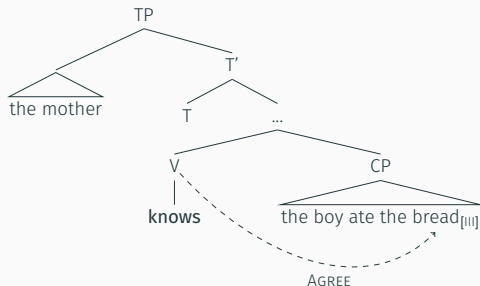
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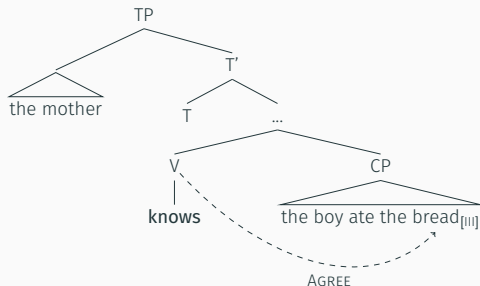
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- Additional facts: LDA can *only* target embedded **topics** ($\simeq$ given elements) that are in an **absolutive position**.

Three main workarounds

- The Goal is base-generated in the embedded clause and **covertly moves to its edge, in a specific Topic projection: most likely analysis, we'll focus on this today.**
- Alternative analysis (refuted by P&P, see arguments at the end of this presentation): the Goal is base-generated in the matrix clause as a null element coreferential with its overt counterpart in the embedded clause.
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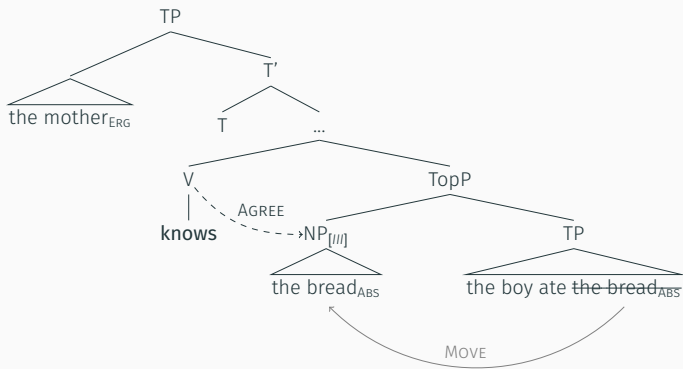
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The analysis at a glance

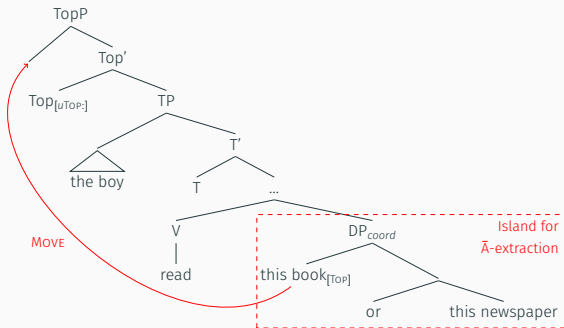
- The Goal is base-generated in the embedded clause and **covertly moves to its edge, in a specific Topic projection**. This is local enough to allow Agreement with the matrix predicate.
- This also explains the topic-restriction of LDA.



LDA and topicalization

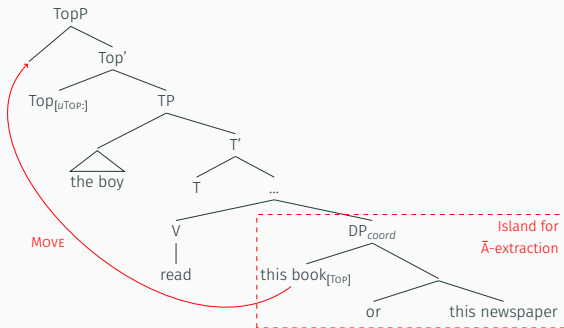
Tsez topics

- Tsez has two **topic markers** *-no* and *-gon*.
- These are shown to trigger **topicalization** (an $\bar{A}$ operation), moving the topic-marked element to the edge of the clause.
- **This can happen covertly**; we know because *-no*/*-gon* cannot occur inside islands. This would be weird if movement was absent, but fully expected if movement is present—recall $\bar{A}$ -operations like topicalization are island-sensitive!



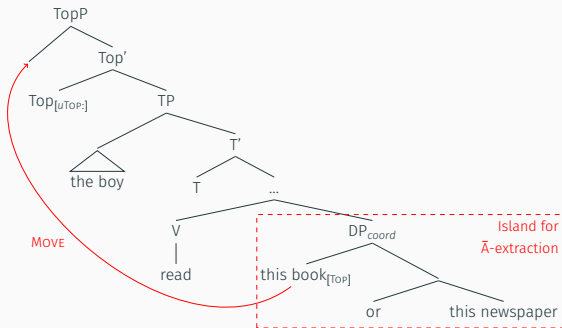
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Topic-marking forces LDA

- If the embedded absolutive element topic-marked, LDA between this topic and the matrix verb becomes obligatory.

(5) enir [už-ā magalu-(go)n b-āc'ruḷi] b-iyxo
mother boy.ERG bread.III.ABS.TOPIC III-eat III-know
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Intended: 'About the bread, the mother knows the boy ate it.'

- Given that topic marking (morphology) forces topicalization (movement to the clause edge), **topicalization can be understood as forcing LDA**.
- P&P also show that elements which *cannot* be topics, cannot trigger LDA, strengthening the topic-LDA correlation.

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Topicalization of a non-absolutive inhibits LDA

- Suppose a non-absolutive argument of the embedded clause gets topicalized (could be ensured using topic marker *-(go)n*).
- The absolutive argument of the sentence, which is the only suitable Goal for LDA, will *not* be able to undergo topicalization, and will remain too far from the matrix Probe!
- This line of reasoning predicts LDA to be blocked in that scenario: borne out.

- (7) a. eni-r [hul už-ā magalu b-āc'ruŋi]
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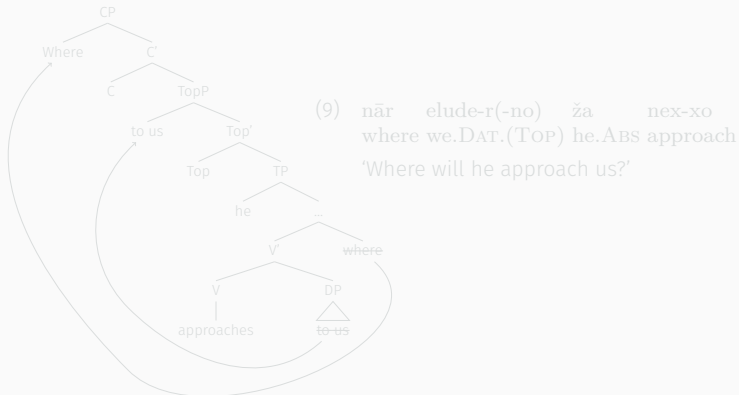
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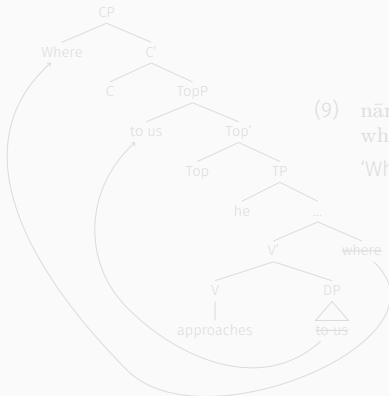
TopP and CP

- Why not assume that topics move to Spec-CP?
- Overt *wh*-movement and topicalization can occur *together* in Tsez, in which case the fronted *wh*-element precedes the topic.
- This is evidence that CP, if present, dominates TopP. P&P take that **these projections are present iff filled**.



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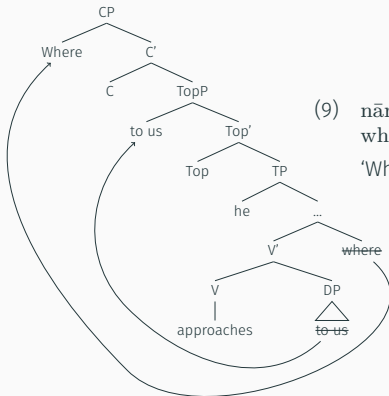
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LDA blocking by *wh*-words

- Prediction: if the embedded clause has a CP, LDA should not be **possible**, because the absolute Goal would remain unreachable for the matrix Probe.
- One way to make sure a CP is there, is to have a *wh*-word in the clause. P&P have evidence that even if this *wh*-word remains *in situ*, it moves covertly to Spec-CP!

- (10) a. enir [lu micxir b-ok'āk'ruli]
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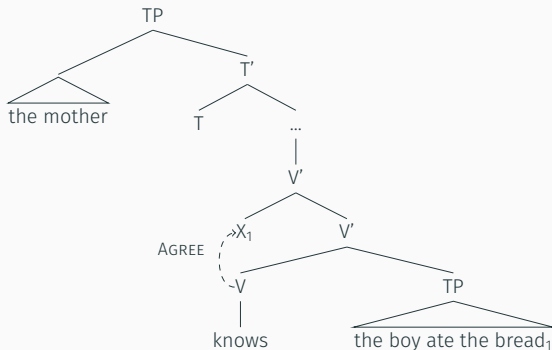
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Rejecting alternatives analyses

Alternative matrix base-generation approach

- Suppose the Goal is in fact base-generated in the matrix clause as a null element coreferential with its overt counterpart in the embedded clause.
- AGREE can take place in the matrix!



Refuting the matrix base-generation approach

- P&P show the null element X_1 should be a pronoun or anaphor, which would represent an *ad hoc* assumption given general facts about Tsez null pros.
- Analysis incorrectly predicts the matrix Goal to sometimes be overt instead of covert.
- It does not explain why only embedded *absolute* Goals can trigger LDA
- Incorrectly predicts LDA to be clause-unbounded (you can create a chain of coreferential null pros, one per clause).
- Incorrectly predicts scopal interactions between the LDA Goal and matrix subject quantified expressions.
- Incorrectly predicts the LDA Goal to bind matrix anaphors.

Refuting an alternative matrix movement approach

- Suppose the Goal is base-generated in the embedded clause and moves to the matrix.
- This movement cannot be overt, because it would screw up word order.⁸ Additionally, if the embedded clause gets dislocated, the LDA Goal “follows” so it must be part of it.
- This movement cannot be A-movement, because otherwise the ergative DP (higher in the embedded clause) should trigger LDA. Also, it would incorrectly predict the binding/scope interactions pointed out in the previous slide.
- And it cannot be A-bar because there’s independent evidence that A-bar movement in Tsez is clause-bounded. Also, it would incorrectly predict the scope interactions pointed out in the previous slide.

⁸Even given that Tsez allows (clause -internal!) scrambling

Focusing on the scopal interaction counterargument

(12) **Some** teacher likes **every** boy.

There's one teacher that likes every boy ($\exists > \forall$)

For every boy, there's a teacher who likes him ($\forall > \exists$)

- If a quantified absolute topic indeed ends up in the matrix clause, either as a pro or after movement, we expect it to **interact scopally with other quantified expressions in the matrix...**
- Not borne out! The absolute topic can only be interpreted in the scope of a quantified matrix subject. It cannot scope over it.

(13) sis učitelər šibaw užı ø-ik'ixosili ø-iyxo
one teacher every boy-I.ABS I-go I-know

'Some teacher is s.t. they know that every boy is going ($\exists > \forall$).'

*'For every boy, some teacher knows that he's going ($\forall > \exists$).'

References i



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